Competitor research · October 2026 · For the wellness ritual app brief

Ten apps people already use to breathe, sit, journal and take herbs.

For each app: what it is, what it costs, how it is rated, its strengths, its weaknesses, and the one lesson Tend takes from it. The apps are grouped by the part of the brief they compete with.

Meditation

Headspace, Calm, Balance, Insight Timer

Breathwork

Othership, Breathwrk, Open

Journal

Stoic

Herbal

HealisticMD, Herbal Natural Care

Desk research from app store listings and published reviews (Simply Psychology, Choosing Therapy, Healthline, TechRadar, T3, Sleep Foundation and others). Ratings and prices are U.S. listings at the time of writing and change often. Where a source is a vendor or an automated review summary, it is marked. No user interviews were run for this report.

At a glance

"Tailors to you" records what reviewers say each app adapts to. Blank means no source said.

App	Core of the product	Price (U.S.)	Rating	Tailors to you
Meditation				
Headspace	Guided meditation with a beginner path	$12.99 / mo, $69.99 / yr, $399.99 lifetime	4.8, about 1M App Store reviews	Goals and usage; "better than average but not deep"
Calm	Sleep Stories, meditation, breathing, music	Free tier; Premium varies		Customisable, with a large catalogue
Balance	Personalised meditation plans	$11.99 / mo, $69.99 / yr, $399.99 lifetime; one-year free trials in promotions	4.9 (95.4K App Store), 4.7 (35.8K Google Play)	Level, how often you sit, skills mastered
Insight Timer	Huge free library and a timer	Free; MemberPlus $9.99 / mo, $59.99 / yr	4.5 / 5 (Choosing Therapy)	You choose; little guidance
Breathwork				
Othership	Music-led breathwork classes	$17.99 / mo, $129.99 / yr	4.9, about 2,100 U.S. reviews	Daily styles by the state you want (up, down)
Breathwrk	Short guided breathing exercises	Free tier; Pro $9 / mo, $49 / yr	4.8 (16.6K App Store), 3.7 (692 Google Play)	Voice, sound and duration settings
Open	Breathwork, meditation, movement, plus a studio	Free download; paid tiers not stated in listings	4.9 (397 reviews in one store)	
Journal				
Stoic	Morning and evening journal with mood tracking	Free with in-app purchases	4.8, about 35K App Store reviews	Prompts by time of day
Herbal				
HealisticMD	AI companions for natural remedies	Free with in-app purchases		Tracks what seems to help you
Herbal Natural Care	Ayurvedic herb reference	App store listing		None; a reference

Headspace

Meditation · market leader

The easiest meditation app to recommend to a beginner: a guided path, a friendly voice and a distinctive illustrated look.

Price	Rating	Best for
$12.99 / mo, $69.99 / yr, $399.99 lifetime, 7-day trial	4.8 from about 1M App Store reviews (July 2025)	Complete beginners who do not want to browse

Strengths

- Visual design reviewers call distinctive and genuinely good; easy to navigate.
- Clear, professional narration, much of it by co-founder Andy Puddicombe, gives the app one trusted voice.
- A structured path removes the “what should I do” problem for beginners.
- Personalisation has improved, using stated goals and usage.

Weaknesses

- Personalisation is “better than average but not deep”; it follows your history, not how you feel today.
- Engagement with mindfulness apps drops sharply after week one; streaks and badges only partly help.
- Not built for clinical needs such as anxiety disorders or depression.
- Built around meditation; no herbal guidance.

Tend takes: one obvious next step and one consistent voice.

Tend avoids: streaks and badges as the answer to week-two drop-off.

Calm

Meditation and sleep

The sleep app of the category: Sleep Stories read by well-known actors, plus meditation, breathing, music and movement.

Price	Best for	Content
Free tier; Premium price varies by offer	Falling asleep	Sleep Stories, box and belly breathing, soundscapes, kids’ content

Strengths

- Sleep Stories are the standout, with narrators such as Matthew McConaughey and Cillian Murphy.
- Easy-to-use interface and regular updates (Healthline); highly customisable, varied content (TechRadar).
- Includes guided breathing techniques such as box breathing and deep exhales.
- Family-friendly content for children.

Weaknesses

- Somewhat expensive with a short trial; the free version has far fewer features.
- No sleep monitoring, despite being the sleep app.
- Stories can run too long and nature sounds can distract.
- Some options are hidden; no social features.

Tend takes: an evening mode that ends the day softly.

Tend avoids: a catalogue so big the best options hide; sound on by default.

Balance

Personalised meditation

The closest to Tend's promise in meditation: plans that adapt as you progress, with a very long free trial.

Price
$11.99 / mo, $69.99 / yr, $399.99 lifetime; one-year free trial in promotions

Rating
4.9 (95.4K App Store), 4.7 (35.8K Google Play)

Best for
Beginners who want to be guided

Strengths

- Personalises by meditation level, how often you sit and which skills you have mastered.
- Audio adapts as you progress.
- A small library that does not overwhelm beginners; praised for calm, simple guidance.
- The long free trial lowers the barrier to start.

Weaknesses

- About 60 meditations and 20 plans: small next to Headspace and Calm.
- Billing complaints: charged after cancelling on the last trial day; "Free year is a lie".
- Unsubscribing is hard for some; streak tracking bugs.
- Tailoring follows your skill, not your state today. Meditation only.

Tend takes: a small, curated library that adapts.

Tend avoids: any trial or billing flow that feels like a trap.

Insight Timer

Free library

The biggest free library in the category, a flexible timer, and a community of teachers.

Price
Free; MemberPlus $9.99 / mo, $59.99 / yr

Rating
4.5 / 5 (Choosing Therapy, July 2026)

Scale
170,000+ free meditations, plus yoga, mood tracking, workshops

Strengths

- One of the largest free libraries anywhere; most people never need to pay.
- A plain timer for people who already know what they want.
- A reviewer praised its calm interface, free of manipulative streaks and gamification.
- Mood tracking, mentoring and workshops beyond meditation.

Weaknesses

- Content overload; the interface feels cluttered and discovery filters clunky.
- Offline listening, the advanced player and most courses sit behind MemberPlus.
- Uneven quality across tracks (reported in review summaries).
- No guidance on what to do today; the choice is all yours.

Tend takes: no streaks, and a plain timer option.

Tend avoids: choice overload; we choose for you, and say why.

Othership

Breathwork · premium

Music-driven breathwork classes, sorted by the state you want to reach.

Price	Rating	Library
$17.99 / mo, $129.99 / yr; 7 and 14-day trials	4.9 from about 2,100 U.S. App Store reviews	500+ classes; styles UP, DOWN, All Around, Body, Brain

Strengths

- Sessions are named by the state they serve (up, down), not by technique, which matches how people think.
- Music is matched to each session's tone; T3 calls it a great introduction to breathwork.
- Streaks, progress and a global community.
- Very high rating from a sizeable base.

Weaknesses

- Music can drown the vocal instructions (T3).
- The most expensive app here; price is the recurring complaint.
- Breath only: no stillness, herbs or reflection in the same flow.

Tend takes: name practices by the state they serve.

Tend avoids: sound that competes with guidance; ours is quiet ambient, off by choice.

Breathwrk

Breathwork · short sessions

More than 50 short breathing exercises for calm, sleep, energy and performance, many of them one or two minutes long.

Price	Rating	Format
Free tier; Pro $9 / mo, $49 / yr, 7-day trial	4.8 (16.6K App Store), 3.7 (692 Google Play)	Timed inhales, holds and exhales with music, haptics and lessons

Strengths

- Very short sessions fit into any day.
- Adjustable voice, sounds and duration; progress tracking.
- Haptics let you breathe with eyes closed; "Breathe With Friends".
- Users credit it with helping anxiety and relaxation.

Weaknesses

- Limited free content and a mandatory sign-up before you can try anything.
- Reports of hard cancellation and unexpected charges.
- A redesign drew backlash: harder navigation, lost favourites, health-app sync issues, crashes (automated review summaries).
- The 3.7 Google Play rating shows an uneven experience across platforms.

Tend takes: sessions measured in minutes, and a counted pattern on screen.

Tend avoids: sign-up before value; "Look around as Lena" works without an account.

Open

Breathwork, meditation, movement

A studio brand from Los Angeles with an app: breathwork, meditation and movement designed with experts in neurobiology.

Price	Rating	Channel
Free download; paid tiers not stated in the listings we found	4.9 from 397 reviews in one store; small samples elsewhere	App plus an in-person flagship studio

Strengths

- Three practices in one product, close to Tend's mix.
- A credible, expert-led positioning.
- An in-person studio gives the brand a physical home and community.

Weaknesses

- Few independent reviews; hard to judge depth or pricing from outside.
- The brand leans on the LA studio, which most users will never visit.
- No herbal guidance and no visible day-by-day tailoring in its listing.

Tend takes: several practices in one ritual.

Tend avoids: expert claims without showing the reasoning in the product.

Stoic

Journal

A guided journal built around a morning to prepare and an evening to reflect, with mood tracking and habits.

Price	Rating	Platforms
Free with in-app purchases; premium for AI and guided content	4.8 from about 35K App Store reviews; Apple Editors' Choice	iPhone, iPad, Mac, Apple Watch, Vision Pro

Strengths

- A clear daily rhythm: prepare in the morning, reflect in the evening.
- Prompts, mood tracking and habits in one place.
- Strong ratings and Apple's editorial backing.

Weaknesses

- Apple only, with no web app.
- Limited AI depth (a competitor's comparison, so weigh it).
- Reflection only; it does not lead into a practice.

Tend takes: morning and evening as two different moods of the same app.

Tend avoids: the journal as a separate chore; ours is one line at the end of the ritual.

HealisticMD

Herbal · AI companions

AI wellness companions for natural treatments, available around the clock, that track what seems to help you.

Price	Positioning	Disclaimer
Free with in-app purchases	A team of AI wellness companions	States it does not provide medical advice

Strengths

- Always-on conversation lowers the effort of asking.
- Tracks over time what helps your body, a feedback loop most apps lack.
- Free to start.

Weaknesses

- The listing does not show how advice is sourced or checked against medicines.
- A disclaimer stands in for safety design.
- No breath, meditation or reflection around the remedy.

Tend takes: learn what helps over time.

Tend avoids: unsourced herbal advice; every herb shows its cautions, evidence and source.

Herbal Natural Care

Herbal · reference

An Ayurvedic herb database: medicinal herbs, what they are used for and how to prepare them.

Price	Format	Best for
App store listing	Searchable reference	Looking up a herb you already know

Strengths

- Breadth of herbs with uses and preparation.
- Useful for people who already know what they want.

Weaknesses

- A reference, not a routine; it never tells you what to do today.
- No personal safety checks against pregnancy, medicines or allergies.

Tend takes: preparation shown step by step.

Tend avoids: herbs without a person in mind.

Where the gap is

- **Nobody plans today from how you feel today.** Headspace and Balance tailor to your history and skill; Othership sorts by the state you choose; none asks first and then decides.
- **Practices live in separate apps.** Breath (Othership, Breathwrk), stillness (Headspace, Calm), reflection (Stoic) and herbs (HealisticMD) are each someone else's product. Only Open combines practices, without herbs.
- **Herbal apps lack safety design.** The two herbal apps either list herbs or talk about them; neither shows advice checked against medicines, pregnancy or allergies, with evidence and a source.
- **The category's complaints are about trust, not features:** billing traps (Balance, Breathwrk), sign-up walls (Breathwrk), clutter (Insight Timer), sound over guidance (Othership, Calm).

Sources

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